

Call for Participation

According to the United Nations, just over half of global households (55%) have an Internet connection. In low and middle income countries, only 47% do and that number falls to just 19% in least developed countries.

There are profound implications to having about 2.9 billion unconnected or under-connected people across the globe. These digitally disadvantaged populations lack access to meaningful connectivity needed for an equitable digital inclusion. Affordable digital connectivity in rural areas enables access to basic daily needs such as online education for children, remote healthcare for pregnant, newborns, elderly and those who are not well, access to financial institutions etc. At the same time, it also helps businesses to create a digital marketplace to sell their goods and services and find new customers by participating in the online economy, which otherwise is difficult in absence of connectivity.

In light of this dire and increased need, the IEEE Future Networks Technical Community (FNTC) has endeavored to support a competition to identify and award innovative ideas and early-stage projects which have potential to connect the unconnected. By recognizing innovative individuals or organizations, IEEE can raise awareness of the digital divide and encourage new entrepreneurial efforts to provide internet access to unconnected populations.

The 2026 competition has two main tracks:

1. **Concept-Only track:** These are individuals or groups who have novel ideas that only exist “on paper” with simulation or analytical results, demonstrating potential towards the CTU vision of affordably connecting unconnected populations. Prizes in this track will be lower than the POC track.
2. **Proof-of-Concept track:** This category is intended for individuals or groups who have already demonstrated their innovation with a basic proof-of-concept implementation or a pilot program and can show preliminary results, or successful field deployment(s). The submission in this category should include a description of the general design and proposed functionality including implementation of specific features that are novel/innovative. In addition to implementation, it can include a (small-scale) deployment/exercise to verify the idea's potential and/or to illustrate its feasibility. It should be noted that the competition is not looking for well-established programs with a large user base or extremely advanced initiatives.

Furthermore, FNTC recognizes that the digital divide is not solely a technical problem, and that innovation is needed to overcome many impediments to connectivity. Not being online could be a problem of availability, affordability, or even appetite (cases when people do not use the internet

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even where connectivity exists). In order to address these challenges, the Connecting the Unconnected Challenge has created three subcategories within each track: submissions focused on innovative **Technology Applications (TA)** to increase broadband access or otherwise enable connectivity; submissions focused on innovative **Business Models (BM)** that result in increased affordability or innovative programs that increase demand; and submissions focused on innovative approaches for **Community Enablement (CE)** or the likelihood that populations choose to adopt available broadband access when previously they did not.

Why participate?

Cash prizes will be distributed to winners in the different tracks, with no individual award exceeding \$10,000. Proof-of-Concept prizes are typically higher than Concept-Only prizes. Additionally, this program will provide awardees with opportunities for significant exposure from IEEE, and winning contestants will be invited to participate in a mentorship program, and may be invited present their solutions at a future IEEE Connecting the Unconnected Summits, events that will also include keynote talks, panels and other presentations from leaders in industry, governments, and NGOs. Winning contestants are also invited to present their solutions at the IEEE Connecting the Unconnected Winners Summit which will take place in December 2026.

Who can apply?

The competition is open to private sector companies or startups, nonprofits and grassroots groups, university projects, students, government organizations, any other organization or individual participants from anywhere in the world. Individual participants must be at least 18 years old. Participants do not have to be IEEE members and require no recommendation from an IEEE group or member, any one is eligible to apply.

Participants who represent underserved communities from low and middle income countries and/or the Global South are highly encouraged to apply.

Competition rules and expectations

The competition will be executed in three stages, each stage is conducted officially in English. In the first stage (Phase 1) participants will submit a short initial submission that includes a 500-word abstract describing their solution. Those who advance to Phase 2 will be asked to complete a second, more detailed online submission, to which applicants may attach additional supporting materials. In Phase 3 (final), a select number of applicants will be invited to present to our Selection Committee in a closed-door, live/virtual session with Q&A (questions and answers). The whole process is expected to last approximately 3 months from start to finish. Winners will be recognized at an awards ceremony during the IEEE Connecting the Unconnected Global Summit.

- During Phase 2, applicants will have the option to have their submission reviewed by the IEEE Standards Association (IEEE SA), for potential standardization opportunities within

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their Rural Communication program. This review is voluntary and has no bearing on the competition judging process.

- Phase 2 applicants will also have the option to have their submission reviewed by additional IEEE organizational unit for consideration of special recognition. These recognition may or may not include monetary prizes as determined by specific IEEE organizational unit. This review is voluntary and has no bearing on the competition judging process.
- All phase 2 entrees will be required to create a video of their solution which can be posted publicly by IEEE. We do not envision this video as requiring any cost burden, and IEEE will provide recommendations for video creation. Videos are required to be submitted in English, but an additional video may be submitted in an additional language.
- All finalists will be required to present their solution during a live/virtual session with the selection committee in October 2026.
- All finalists will be required to undergo a due diligence procedure to verify submitted information before the final ranking is determined.
- Some winners/awardees may be invited to present at future CTU Global or Regional Summits. In-person attendance is requested for those who present, but virtual presentation methods will also be made available.
- All winners/awardees will be invited to present at the CTU Winners Summit which takes place in December 2026. This event is virtual and recording presentation methods will also be made available if live participation is not possible.
- All winners/awardees will be required to provide updated information about their solution 1 year following the award date as part of a summit “check in”. However, IEEE will not conduct any follow-up audit.

Selected submissions may be encouraged or invited to publish in IEEE publications. Selected submissions may also be encouraged or invited to participate in IEEE Standards Association projects.

Award Criteria

The submissions will be assessed based on a number of technical and societal impact criteria. These will include novelty/innovation of the idea/project and relevance to the CTU topic, as well as scalability, sustainability (from a business/deployment perspective) and readiness of the proposed solution. The submissions will be also evaluated on their potential for inclusion, impact, efficacy and risk level.

Deadlines:

Phase 1 submission closing: June 17, 2026

Phase 1 notifications: Approximately one month later

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Phase 2 submission closing: August 2026

Phase 2 notifications: Approximately one month later

Phase 3 presentations: October 2026

Winner notifications: November 2026

CTU Global Winners Summit: December 2026

Frequently Asked Questions:

- **Will I be required to spend the award money in accordance with a project plan?**

No. This is prize money provided with the intention to foster innovation, not a project grant with expected deliverables. However, award winners will be asked to provide updated information on the outcome of their solution the following year.

- **Do all participants need to be over the age of 18?**

Yes.

- **I'm concerned about sharing confidential information about my early-stage initiative. What will get shared publicly or even broadly within IEEE?**

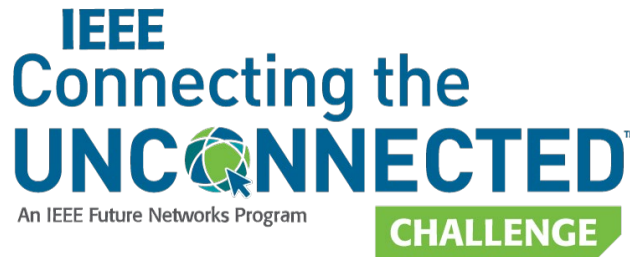
Our Selection Committee members commit to limiting disclosure of information you consider confidential. Participants may be asked, either in the submission template or in a closed-door session with the selection committee, to share information which participants consider confidential for the purpose of the committee. Such information will not be shared outside of this committee.

Awardees will not be asked to share confidential information during the Summit, where winners will be publicly announced.

All participants are encouraged to seek patent protection for their solutions.

- **My solution is very advanced; we have a vast number of users and are looking to increase our scale. Should I submit for the competition?**

No. The purpose of the competition is to foster new innovation and early-stage work, not solutions in an advanced implementation phase looking to scale.



- **Does my submission need to be in English?**

Yes, all submissions, reviews, and interviews will be conducted in English. Additional information (details, presentations, videos, etc) can be submitted in separate files, but these are voluntary and has no bearing on the competition judging process.

- **I am not an IEEE member; can I still submit a solution?**

Yes, the contest is open to everyone over the age of 18.

- **Do you favor sophisticated, well written applications from academics or highly technical organizations?**

No. Innovations can come from anywhere, and representatives from rural areas or the Global South are highly encouraged to apply. Participants with innovations which are not technical in nature but innovative in other respects are encouraged to apply.

- **When will the prize money be awarded?**

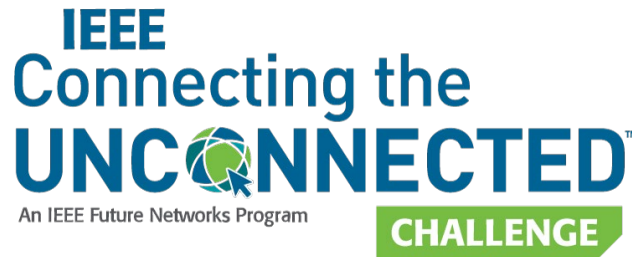
Following announcement at the winners summit, award payments shall be rendered, this is typically a 3 month process.

- **How is the prize money paid?**

Award payments shall be rendered to the main submitter as an individual. Payments will not be made to multiple individuals or to companies.

- **Am I allowed to use AI on my submission?**

Participants are welcome to utilize AI technologies in their submissions. However, it is crucial to disclose the use of AI in your project. This includes identifying the AI systems used and explaining the extent to which AI contributed to your project. Transparency in AI usage helps ensure the integrity and credibility of your submission. For detailed guidelines on how to properly cite AI-generated content, please refer to the IEEE Author Guidelines for Artificial Intelligence (AI)-Generated Text, <https://open.ieee.org/author-guidelines-for-artificial-intelligence-ai-generated-text/>



- **Am I allowed to modify my submission from phase to phase?**

Participants have the opportunity to update and modify their proposals from phase to phase. This allows participants to modify their proposal to make it more valuable and ubiquitous to the CTU community. However, it is important to note that a submission cannot be completely changed or replaced with an entirely new idea/project. Submissions must maintain the core concept and focus from the previous phase while incorporating updates and refinements based on feedback and further development.

- **What if my question is not answered here in the FAQ?**

You can always email us via the contact information in the footer of this document.



About IEEE: [The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers \(IEEE\)](#) is the world's largest professional association dedicated to advancing technological innovation and excellence for the benefit of humanity. IEEE and its members inspire a global community through IEEE's highly cited publications, conferences, technology standards, and professional and educational activities.

About IEEE Future Networks: [The IEEE Future Networks Technical Community \(FNTC\)](#) was designed to help pave a clear path through development and deployment of 5G and the great potential it enables, while envisioning the landscape of connectivity and applications beyond 5G. Recognizing that networking is larger than a single technology, standard, organization, or region, FNTC is gathering the world's researchers, scientists, engineers, and policymakers from industry, academia, and governments to solve the challenges and reveal the opportunities associated with current and future networks. In 2019 FNTC created a working group called Connecting the Unconnected, which contributed a chapter to the International Network Generations Roadmap (INGR), proposing ideas whereby future network generation upgrades should have connectivity included as a standard, rather than considered as an afterthought.